October 29, 2026 Dark Days Ahead

“In order for the light to shine so brightly, the darkness must be present.”

— Francis Bacon



Halloween is upon us, and scary things will go bump in the night. The clocks will all be set back an hour, the sun will set an hour earlier, and will keep creeping back over the next two more months until it slowly begins to reverse direction. The boat is tucked in for its winter hibernation, wrapped in a forest green tarp under the trees. Chipmunks are headed underground, but not without first standing at their doorways pleading ceaselessly for someone to come down and be company for the long winter ahead. The maples are greedily sopping up the remaining sunshine and color to spread a red and gold quilt to cover their impending freezing feet. One sleeps better, I am told, if one wears socks to bed. We are headed into the season of long nights and short days. I look forward to it.

Darkness comes now; the darkness that reveals to us the brightness of the stars…the ones that were always there just beyond our perception. It pulls on our eyes and our longing to the cozy warmth and hominess of lamps in windows and stirs our yearning to be included as we walk throughout the town. The darkness invites us to look inward more than outward. The darkness, which—expansive as it may be—cannot extinguish a single candle; in fact, it makes the flame seem warmer and brighter. Darkness pervades in the deep soil where those same maple tree roots rest and grow in order to find nourishment and light-gathering impulses to send up to the leaves when they emerge again in a few months.

Soon we’ll decorate with lights to remind us of light that will come and that is already and always present—if we would only look. Those lights don’t only remind me of the light that will come; they also remind me of the blessings of darkness we too often fail to appreciate. Periods and whole seasons of darkness—of quiet, slower pace, rest, being together, celebrating, storing up to give away, remembering and hoping, waiting and dreaming. And, when we can, lighting more candles. From spring through early fall, I’ll love the warm days and long hours of sunshine again, but at the same time I’ll be rebuilding and storing up appreciation and anticipation of the season of darkness to follow. The cycle itself renews and deepens the blessing. I’m ready, so bring it!

But first…Thanksgiving.

Happy Thinksday.